were lost. Significantly, wary of each other's missiles, particularly those launched beyond visual range (BVR), both forces operated well within their respective air space. However, on May 8 and 10, after Indian missile and drone strikes took out vital Pakistani air defence radars in Lahore and Karachi—one precious PAF AWACS was reportedly lost too—its air defence systems were rendered toothless, largely driving the PAF from the skies. So, after Pakistan targeted Indian air bases and military installations with drones and missiles on May 9 and 10—almost all of which were intercepted and shot to pieces—it was helpless before India's retaliatory barrage of SCALP and BrahMos supersonic missiles, fired by aircraft and from the ground on eight Pakistani air bases, including the Nur Khan base near Rawalpindi, the general headquarters of the Pakistan army. Thus chastened, Pakistan is said to have called for a ceasefire.

Operation Sindoor was a demonstration of Indian precision and reach, and showcased India's capability to strike any target in Pakistan at will. Frank O'Donnell, senior research adviser at the Asia-Pacific Leadership Network and non-resident fellow at the Stimson Center, says that it signals India's ability for precision strikes on targets within each base and suggests its implicit capacity to incapacitate these bases if desired. "The very short flight time of India's air-to-ground missiles, and especially its reported use of the supersonic BrahMos, leveraged the continuing challenge for Pakistan of operationalising missile defence systems and the extreme difficulty of blocking cruise missile strikes. However, this challenge is also shared by India," he says.

OPPOSING AIR WARRIORS

Though in recent decades India has held a qualitative and numerical advantage in air superiority over Pakistan, the latter's acquisition of sophisticated Chinese aircraft has led analysts to suggest that the technological disparity is narrowing.

Among India's frontline fighter jets, the Mirage 2000H, armed with the Thales RDY radar (range: 100-130 km) and MICA missiles (both beyond visual range or BVR and short range or SR, with a reach of 60-80 km), excels in precision strikes but has an ageing airframe. The MiG-29UPG, with Zhuk-ME radar (range: 120 km) and R-77 missiles (BVR, with a range of 80-100 km) is agile, but lags in networking. The Su-30MKI, equipped with a Bars PESA radar (or a Passive Electronically Scanned Array radar with a 200 km range) and BrahMos missiles, offers long-range strike capability but has a large radar cross-section, meaning it can be detected by enemy radars. The Rafale has an RBE2 AESA (Active Electronically Scanned Array) radar and SPECTRA electronic warfare suite, which ensures data fusion across electromagnetic, laser and infrared domains to protect it from threats. Both PESA and AESA radars can track multiple targets at once. The Rafale, armed with Meteor and SCALP

SHIELDS UP AB

INDIA



S-400 TRIUMF 'SUDARSHAN CHAKRA'

Russian-made long-range surface-to-air missile system or SAM (400 km), intercepts aircraft, drones, missiles. Outclasses Pakistan's systems

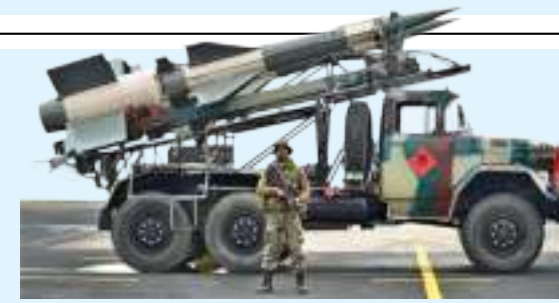
OP SINDOOR: Reportedly downed 8 Pakistani missiles in Jammu (May 8-9)



BARAK-8

Developed with Israel, long-range SAM (70-100 km), AESA radar

OP SINDOOR: Countered drones/ missiles



ON TARGET A Pechora missile system

PECHORA, TUNGUSKA, OSA-AK

Russian-made short-range SAM/ guns (10-20 km); mobile and rapid-response weapons

OP SINDOOR: Effectively protected Indian air bases like Pathankot

BOFORS L-70, ZSU-23-4 SCHILKA

Radar-linked, self-propelled low-level air defence (LLAD) guns

OP SINDOOR: With MANPADS like Igla-M, Igla-S, shot down hundreds of Pakistani drones in swarms



LEGACY GUN The Bofors L-70 self-propelled gun is an old workhorse